

REBEL LEADERS / FIELD TOOL 04

Mandate Reset

THE PRODUCT LEADER'S FIELD GUIDE

Turn an authority gap into a specific decision-rights request leadership can act on.

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For you, the PM carrying this situation

OPEN YOUR LAB >

UNDERSTAND THE PRESSURE. WORK THE SITUATION. LEAVE WITH A MOVE.

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You own the outcome. Can you move the lever?

You're accountable for progress, but the decision that would change it sits somewhere else. More effort may not resolve that operating condition.

Start with one blocked decision

Which outcome are you expected to deliver? Which specific scope, budget, dependency, or approval decision prevents it? A concrete lever is easier to discuss than a general feeling of powerlessness.

Distinguish influence from authority

You can prepare a recommendation and build understanding without having the final decision right. That distinction matters when your performance depends on a choice only someone else can make.

Your win as the PM

Make the mismatch visible, request a bounded right or escalation rule, and agree what you will do while waiting. You don't need to take over every decision to create a workable path.

How this kit helps

Use the Guide for language and judgment. Use the Lab to map one actual decision. Leave with a Decision Rights Map, an Authority Gap Statement, and a Reset Request.

> A Reset Request proposes a change. It does not grant permission or cancel an existing approval requirement.

Get clear before you go back into the room.

When you're blamed for an outcome you can't control, it is easy to make the next conversation about fairness alone. Prepare a request the other person can act on.

Separate the event from your interpretation

Write the actual request, words, or decision. Then name the story you're adding about the person. You can feel frustrated and still ask a useful question about their constraints.

Name your Why

What would a working decision path let the team achieve? Connect the reset to customer value, responsible delivery, and less time waiting for conflicting instructions.

Paint a future they can help shape

Describe what better would look like in daily work: customers can plan, the team can focus, or decisions happen before commitments change. Invite the other person to improve the picture. A shared ambition needs their authorship too.

Keep private preparation private

The Lab saves these notes in your browser and excludes them from shared outputs. Export the working brief you want others to see; don't send your untested motive story.

> Try: I want us to make this work. Can we look together at the outcome, the constraints, and the decision we need?

The org chart is a starting point, not the answer.

Describe how this decision actually happens. Then ask the people involved to verify the map.

Recommendation

Who frames the options and brings evidence? That person may be you. A good recommendation makes the consequence of each option clear; it is not the same as approval.

Decision and execution

Who may make the final choice, and who carries it out? A sponsor deciding scope does not replace Engineering's responsibility for technical acceptance or a specialist's required approval.

Constraints and accountability

Who can stop or materially constrain the choice? Who is judged on the outcome? Include legitimate policy and safety controls, not only people who seem difficult.

Confirmed versus assumed

Record which rights come from policy, agreement, or an observed decision. If the final owner is unknown, make naming that owner your next request. Don't turn an uncertain map into organizational fact.

> Decision Rights Map: who recommends, decides, executes, constrains, and carries accountability for this particular decision.

Describe the operating condition without diagnosing the people.

A useful gap statement lets leadership see the lever and its consequence.

Use observable events

Three stakeholders added work to the release. Only the sponsor can approve removing it. Product is still being held to the unchanged delivery date. That is more actionable than nobody respects Product.

Connect the gap to the outcome

Name waiting time, conflicting instructions, repeated rework, or an unowned decision. Attribute estimated costs and distinguish them from observed effects.

Check for a legitimate boundary

Some rights belong elsewhere for good reasons. Security, safety, data, or spending controls may be necessary. The reset should clarify how to work with those owners, not remove them through a clever phrase.

Ask for the missing condition

Is the problem a missing owner, an unclear boundary, inconsistent decisions, or slow response? Choose a request matched to the actual problem.

> Try: I'm accountable for X. Y determines it. At present, I can recommend Y but cannot decide it, and no response rule is agreed.

Ask for a specific right or a workable rule.

Vague empowerment is difficult to grant and difficult to verify. Make the proposed operating change bounded.

Define the right

For this release, may Product sequence scope within the approved budget and outcome, subject to Engineering's acceptance conditions? Name the decision, limits, and retained approvals.

Offer an escalation alternative

If the right stays with the sponsor, ask for a recipient, response time, and agreed interim action. While waiting, keep working within current authority rather than interpreting silence as consent.

Name the response you need

Approve the rule, revise it, decline it with a workable alternative, or identify the correct owner. Ask by a date connected to the actual consequence.

Define a review

After the next two decisions, check whether the rule reduces waiting or conflicting work. A right that exists only in the meeting notes may need another reset.

> Useful request: Every new scope request goes to one sponsor for an explicit displacement decision before the release plan changes.

Give leadership something they can fix.

You can be direct about the mismatch while remaining curious about constraints you may not see.

Open with the shared outcome

I want us to deliver a coherent release and give the team one plan. Here's the decision path we're using and the place where it gets stuck. I'd like to agree a workable rule.

You need to be more influential

Ask which decision you are expected to influence, who retains authority, and what response route supports that responsibility. Influence can help; it doesn't by itself define a decision right.

You already own it

Ask for a concrete example of what you may decide and which limits apply. Invite the sponsor to confirm that boundary with the people who can currently override it.

We can't change the authority

Offer a response rule and safe interim plan. If the risk remains, document the unresolved condition and escalate through the appropriate route. Don't claim an agreement that was not made.

> Try: If the decision stays with you, can we agree how quickly it gets a response and what plan remains in place while we wait?

A roadmap owner with no scope rule.

Fictional case: several executives add requests, one sponsor may displace them, and the PM remains accountable for the roadmap date.

The Decision Rights Map

PM recommends; sponsor decides; Product and Engineering execute. Requesting executives can introduce competing demands. Security keeps its required approval. The sponsor still needs to confirm the proposed operating map.

The Authority Gap Statement

The date depends on scope choices that Product cannot make. New requests are being treated as additions before the sponsor names displaced work. That creates a plan the team cannot reconcile.

The Reset Request

Ask for one sponsor rule: every new request names the displaced commitment before the plan changes. Preserve budget, security, and Engineering acceptance conditions. If disputed, escalate within one working day.

The decision and follow-through

In this fictional case, the sponsor agrees to the response rule before planning and confirms it with requesting executives. PM records the agreement. They review the next two requests for explicit displacement and one updated plan. The Lab example starts with the request, before agreement.

> The PM now has a workable decision route. The sponsor keeps the scope right and commits to using it before the team plan changes.

Map one decision, then make the request portable.

Open your Mandate Reset Lab. Nic's walkthrough demonstrates the same process on a realistic example.

Accountability

Enter the outcome, blocked decision, and consequence. Use private reflection to prepare; those notes don't appear in the exported records.

Decision Rights

Map the five roles and record which rights are verified. Name necessary specialist approvals. Export the map when you need someone to check it.

Reset

Write the gap, requested right or rule, operating boundaries, and fallback. Export the Authority Gap Statement for the conversation.

Request

Name the action owner, response date, decision status, actual response, interim action, and review. Copy, download, or print the Reset Request. The tool doesn't change your organization's permissions.

> Load the fictional example to rehearse the request. Export your own draft first if you need to preserve it.

Use the next conversation to learn.

A useful brief changes what happens next. Give it an owner, take it into your existing work tools, and return to the evidence.

Follow through on one move

Confirm the agreed decision rule with the people it affects. Check the next actual decision: who chose, how long it took, and which plan changed. Revisit a mismatch that continues rather than compensating for it indefinitely.

Rehearse with a trusted peer

Read your opening aloud. Ask: Is the observation fair? Is the recommendation specific? Could the other person disagree without being cast as the villain? Revise the wording before the real conversation.

Keep a record you can return to

Lab drafts stay in this browser on this device. Copy, download, or print your outputs. Export before clearing browser data or moving devices. The tool does not send messages, update your roadmap, or create authority.

Judge the change by what happens

What did the other person hear? Was a decision made? Did anyone act? Review the next real result rather than treating completion of the Lab as proof that the organizational problem is solved.

> You arrive with a situation. You leave with a proposal, a decision record, or a specific question that somebody can act on.